Property Dualism

One substance, two kinds of property: interactionist and epiphenomenalist versions

This workbook consolidates what you have covered in the slideshow and handout. Work through it in order, or jump to the part you need. Every task can be done on your own, so if you missed a lesson you can still catch up. Answers to the recall tasks are at the back: try first, then check.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

In this workbook

1. Where am I now? A self-check
2. Key terms
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4. Argument reconstruction
5. Objections and evaluation
6. Exam practice (3, 5, 12 and 25 marks)
7. Answers

> **Key Thesis**
> There is only one category of substance, **physical substance**, but there are two categories of **property**: physical and mental. At least some mental properties are **neither reducible to nor supervenient upon** physical properties. The brain has a mass of about a kilo, and it also has the property of seeing a bright colour or feeling elated.

Part 01 Where am I now?

How to use this section

Tick a column for each statement **before** you start, then again **when you finish**. Green = I could explain it to someone else. Amber = I half get it. Red = not yet.

I can...	Start	End
state property dualism and contrast it with substance dualism	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain the difference between substance and property	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain supervenience and why the property dualist denies it	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain interactionist property dualism with an example	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain epiphenomenalism and why Jackson defends it	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain the four objections to epiphenomenalism	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
reach and defend a judgement on property dualism	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G

Part 02 Key terms

Task 1 · Match the term to its definition

Write the letter of the correct definition next to each term.

Term	Letter
Property	
Property dualism	
Supervenience	
Interactionist property dualism	
Epiphenomenalism	
Qualia	
Causally efficacious	
Phenomenology	

	Definition
A	Intrinsic, non-intentional phenomenal properties that are introspectively accessible.
B	Physical events cause mental properties, but mental properties cause nothing physical: one-way causation.
C	Able to bring about effects.
D	A supervenes on B if there can be no change in A without a change in B.
E	A feature or characteristic of a substance, e.g. mass, shape, being in pain.
F	One kind of substance (physical) but two kinds of property: physical and mental.
G	Mental properties and physical properties causally affect each other in both directions.
H	How our mental life seems from the inside, e.g. pain seeming to cause our wincing.

Task 2 · Fill the gaps

Use the word bank. Each word is used once.

Key idea Word bank: weight · hungry · Epiphenomenal · Jackson · Interactionist · substance · property · evolution

Property dualism holds there is only one kind of _____ but two kinds of _____. The brain has physical properties, such as its _____, and mental properties, such as feeling elated. _____ property dualism says mental properties can cause physical events, so feeling _____ can send me to the kitchen. _____ property dualism, defended by Frank _____, says mental properties make no difference to the physical world. A key objection comes from _____: traits that do nothing should not have been selected.

Task 3 · In your own words

Explain the difference between saying the mind is a *thing* (substance dualism) and saying the mind is a set of *properties* (property dualism). Use the brain as your example.

Part 03 Quick recall

How to use this section

Answer from memory first. Then check your notes, and add anything you missed in a different colour. That second colour shows you exactly what to revise.

1. How does property dualism differ from substance dualism?

2. Give one physical and one mental property of the brain.

3. What does it mean to say mental properties are not supervenient on physical ones?

4. Give an example of two-way interaction for interactionist property dualism.

5. What is epiphenomenalism?

6. Why did Jackson accept epiphenomenalism?

7. State the evolutionary objection.

8. State the other-minds objection to epiphenomenalism.

Part 04 Argument reconstruction

How to use this section

Each argument below has been jumbled. Number the lines into the right order (premises first, conclusion last). Then answer the questions underneath. Being able to set out an argument in standard form is exactly what the 5-mark and 12-mark questions reward.

The evolutionary objection to epiphenomenalism

Order	Jumbled line
	But qualia (probably) did evolve.
	A trait can only aid survival if it has effects in the physical world.
	If epiphenomenalism is true, qualia have no physical effects.
	Therefore, epiphenomenalism is (probably) false.
	Natural selection preserves traits that are conducive to survival.
	So, if epiphenomenalism is true, qualia could not have been selected for.

→ How might an epiphenomenalist answer using the idea of a by-product (like the heaviness of a polar bear's coat)?

→ Which premise is the strongest? Why?

The introspection objection (spec)

Order	Jumbled line
	Therefore, if epiphenomenalism is true, I could not know that I am in pain.
	If epiphenomenalism is true, my pain plays no causal role in my belief that I am in pain.
	Therefore, epiphenomenalism is false.
	I know that I am in pain by introspection.
	But I do know that I am in pain.

Order	Jumbled line
	Knowledge of X requires that X plays some causal role in my coming to believe X.

→ Which premise could an epiphenomenalist deny? Is that denial plausible?

→ Why is this objection especially awkward for Jackson, given that Mary's argument depends on what she *knows*?

Part 05 Objections and evaluation

How to use this section

For each objection: explain the problem in your own words, write the best response, then judge whether the response works. The hint column is there if you are stuck; cover it up if you want a harder challenge.

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
Phenomenology of mental life	It seems obvious that the hurtfulness of pain makes me avoid it.			
Natural selection / evolution	Idle traits are not selected for.			
Other minds	If minds never cause behaviour, why think others have them?			

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
Introspective self-knowledge (spec)	How can I know about a pain that causes nothing, not even my belief?			
Is it 'over and above' again?	Property dualism may repeat substance dualism's error.			
Interactionism and physics	Mental properties causing physical effects breaks the causal closure of physics.			

Ranking the objections

Which objection is the **most** damaging, and which is the **least**? Justify your choice: a strong objection attacks a key premise and is hard to answer.

Most damaging: _____ because...

_____

_____

_____

Least damaging: _____ because...

_____

_____

_____

Building a judgement

Is property dualism more plausible than substance dualism? Consider whether it escapes the interaction problem, or simply swaps it for the problems of epiphenomenalism.

Key idea Sentence starters: *The strongest argument for this view is... because...* · *However, this is undermined by...* · *A defender might reply that... but this fails / succeeds because...* · *Therefore, on balance...*

Part 06

Exam practice

How to use this section

On Paper 2 the **3-, 5- and 12-mark** questions test **AO1** only: knowledge and understanding, shown through precise, accurate explanation. The **25-mark** question is **5 marks AO1 + 20 marks AO2**: you must argue, evaluate and reach a judgement that your essay supports throughout.

Spend roughly a minute per mark. Plan before you write.

3 marks · What is meant by 'epiphenomenalism'?

Key idea AO1 · A precise definition or short point. One or two accurate sentences; no evaluation needed.

5 marks · Explain the difference between substance dualism and property dualism.

Key idea AO1 · Set out the idea or argument clearly and in logical order. Precise terminology; a standard-form layout often works best.

Planning frame

1. Define substance and property.
2. Substance dualism: two kinds of substance.
3. Property dualism: one substance, two kinds of property; not supervenient.
4. Illustrate with the brain's physical and mental properties.

12 marks · Explain the challenge posed by natural selection to epiphenomenalist dualism, and how the epiphenomenalist might respond.

Key idea AO1 · A full, precise explanation. Show how the ideas connect logically, step by step. Do **not** evaluate: explain.

Planning frame

1. Define epiphenomenalism precisely.
2. Set out the evolutionary argument step by step.
3. Explain why causally idle qualia could not be selected.
4. Explain the by-product response (polar bear's coat) and what it requires.

Extra notes

25 marks · Is epiphenomenalism a convincing account of the mind?

Key idea AO1 (5) + AO2 (20) · State your line of argument in the introduction and keep to it. Every paragraph should argue, not just describe: point → objection → response → mini-judgement. End with a conclusion that follows from what you have argued.

Model structure

Section	What to do	My plan
Introduction	Define the key terms. State your thesis: the answer you will defend.	
Paragraph 1	Why accept it: respects physics, follows from the Mary argument → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 2	The phenomenology objection → reply → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 3	Natural selection → by-product reply → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 4	Introspective self-knowledge / other minds → reply → mini-judgement.	
Conclusion	Restate your judgement and explain **why** the balance of argument supports it. No new arguments.	

Write your essay on lined paper, or continue below.

Reflect

Go back to Part 01 and fill in the **End** column. Which statement is still red or amber? Write one specific thing you will do about it.

Part 07 Answers

How to use this section

Use these to check Parts 02–04. Exam answers are not given here: bring them to your teacher, or mark against the AO guidance.

Task 1 · Matching

Property = E · Property dualism = F · Supervenience = D · Interactionist property dualism = G · Epiphenomenalism = B · Qualia = A · Causally efficacious = C · Phenomenology = H

Task 2 · Gaps

(1) substance · (2) property · (3) weight · (4) Interactionist · (5) hungry · (6) Epiphenomenal · (7) Jackson · (8) evolution

Quick recall

1. It accepts only one (physical) substance; the dualism is of properties, not things.
2. Physical: weighing about a kilo, its size. Mental: seeing a bright colour, feeling elated.
3. Two physically identical beings could differ mentally: fixing the physical facts does not fix the mental facts.
4. A medicine (physical) alters mood (mental); feeling hungry (mental) causes me to walk to the kitchen (physical).
5. The physical causes mental properties, but mental properties have no physical effects.
6. As a consequence of the Mary argument: qualia are non-physical, so to respect physics they must make no physical difference.
7. Natural selection favours traits that aid survival; causally idle qualia could not aid survival, so their evolution is unexplained.
8. We infer others' minds from behaviour; if mental properties never cause behaviour, behaviour gives no evidence of them.

Arguments in order

The evolutionary objection to epiphenomenalism

1. Natural selection preserves traits that are conducive to survival.
2. A trait can only aid survival if it has effects in the physical world.

3. If epiphenomenalism is true, qualia have no physical effects.
4. So, if epiphenomenalism is true, qualia could not have been selected for.
5. But qualia (probably) did evolve.
6. Therefore, epiphenomenalism is (probably) false.

The introspection objection (spec)

1. I know that I am in pain by introspection.
2. Knowledge of X requires that X plays some causal role in my coming to believe X.
3. If epiphenomenalism is true, my pain plays no causal role in my belief that I am in pain.
4. Therefore, if epiphenomenalism is true, I could not know that I am in pain.
5. But I do know that I am in pain.
6. Therefore, epiphenomenalism is false.

Objections: model responses

Objection	Possible response
Phenomenology of mental life	Epiphenomenalist: the brain state causes both the pain and the avoidance; the appearance of mental causation is an illusion.
Natural selection / evolution	Qualia are by-products of brain states that *were* selected for, as a polar bear's heavy coat comes with its warm one.
Other minds	Infer from similar brains, not from behaviour; same brain states, same by-products.
Introspective self-knowledge (spec)	Perhaps knowledge by acquaintance does not need a causal link; a difficult reply to make good.
Is it 'over and above' again?	Property dualist: properties are not mysterious extra things; the knowledge and zombie arguments show they are real.
Interactionism and physics	Perhaps causal closure is an assumption, not a discovery; or this pushes the theorist towards epiphenomenalism.